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~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

‘The Venerable Dead’ *

Godly Scottish Divines, who, though long ago taken to glory,
have profoundly impacted the generations that followed,
by means of their immense practical esteem of God’s Word,
with careful and thorough exegesis and powerful exposition.

Ron Frasco

~~Year 6 Learning Activity: Analysing health related websites and apps~~

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~~Analysing health related websites and apps~~

~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

* A term coined by early American Pastor, Samuel Davies, as quoted by Iain Murray in Revival and Revivalism – “I am as happy as perhaps creation can make me: I enjoy all the necessities and most of the conveniences of life; I have a peaceful study, as a refuge from the hurries and noise of the world around me; the venerable dead are waiting in my library to entertain me ...”

Analysing health related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

Year 6 Learning Activity: Analysing health related websites and apps

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~~Analysing health-related websites and apps~~

~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

Scottish Divines – a primer for Danny

Some time ago, I began to notice a common thread with some of my favorite commentaries – many of them were written by Scottish Presbyterians. They also all seemed to be exceptionally godly men, with an exceedingly high view of God’s Word. About a year ago, I began to compile biographical notes on these men. Then, in God’s providence, you called to invite us on the Reformation tour. I was thrilled (still am) that I get to come and walk where these dear brothers walked.

During these two weeks, we will hear about the spiritual giants – **John Knox, Patrick Henry, John Rogers, Thomas Cromwell, John Bunyan & Isaac Watts** – two of my heroes of the faith, and **Charles Spurgeon** (everyone’s favorite). But there is another list of godly men – the kind of men that early American Pastor, Samuel Davies, referred to as ‘the venerable dead.’ These were premier exegetes who, though less well-known, are most highly regarded by many more than just this one pastor. These are the additional men about whom I will be thinking as we trek about ...

Analysing health-related websites and apps

~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

David Dickson – 1583-1663 – Pastor He was, as Murray captures it, **‘the instrument in the hand of God of numerous conversions.’**, Professor (he played a considerable part in establishing vital, orthodox Christianity throughout the land.’), Theologian, Non-Conformist. Commentaries: Hebrews, Paul’s Epistles, Matthew, Psalms, **Truth’s Victory over Error: Commentary of the Westminster Confession, Therapeutica Sacra – manual of spiritual counsel, etc.**

Robert Haldane – 1764-1842 – very remarkable evangelist! He served in the navy in the war with France and returned home to his family estate – the **Airthrey Castle**, but soon **dedicated his life and wealth to evangelistic efforts** – at home and in India and Africa. In time, **he sold his family’s estate to fund missionary work and establishment of Churches.** Writings: **He only wrote one commentary, an excellent commentary on Romans – the result of many years of study, and Evidences and Authority of Divine Revelation.**

Analysing health-related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

John Brown (of Whitburn) – 1784-1858 (of special note to me personally because he died exactly 100 years before I was born) – Pastor – he was ...

‘singularly devoted to one aim, the exposition and preaching of the Word of God ... he viewed commenting on the Scriptures as his highest privilege and duty ... he was profoundly disturbed at the all too common custom of ministers preaching a truth which was nevertheless not the truth of the text upon which they based their sermon ... he labored quietly and studiously at Biggar, a small town ... amidst the temptations of popularity, the struggles of controversy, and the responsibilities of leadership in his denomination – John Brown remained a spiritual Christian.’ (BTT)

Spurgeon called him, ‘a modern day Puritan.’ His biographer said of him that ‘he not only employed his entire powers in the study of the Scriptures, but resigned his whole being to the empire of the Word of God.’ Iain Murray identifies him as ‘one of the greatest Scottish exegetes of the 19th century.’ I’d

Analysing health-related websites and apps

~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

add about 20 more centuries to that. Writings: Excellent commentary on **Hebrews, Galatians, Christian Pastor's Manual.**

Patrick Fairbairn – 1805-1874 – Pastor Scholar, Theologian. ‘He combined his extensive experience of pastoral work with many years of well-regulated and exacting study of Scripture and the disciplines ancillary to its interpretation.’ (BTT) . Writings: Jonah, Ezekiel, Pastoral Epistles, Interpretation of Prophecy.

John Eadie – 1810-1876 – Pastor, Professor. He pastored his Church in Glasgow for 28 years, where his influence was felt throughout the region. Then was called to Kelvin, which Church he pastored for 13 more years (God does, at times, relocate His servants). One historian noted of him,

... there never was a harder worker than the general divine, who yet bore no visible trace of the toil under the burden of which he sank before his time. He stood apart from the heats

~~Analysing health related websites and apps~~

~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

of controversy and was loved and trusted by men of every creed. His fellow-citizens were proud of him as one whose name was known and honored in the quiet retreats of learning ...

Writings: Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, *History of the English Bible*.

Robert Murray M'Cheyne – 1813-1843 He died at the young age of 30 during a typhus epidemic! Pastor, Evangelist. It is said of him that he 'was widely regarded as one of the most saintly and able young ministers of his day.' (BTT) He was saved by reading David Dickson's (see his earlier mention), *Sum of Saving Knowledge*. He became a capable and beloved preacher and man of God. Of whom Iain Murray remarked, 'he had a remarkable influence in his lifetime'). Writings: ***Bible Reading Plan***, many, many others. One of his famous quotes – "Am I redeeming the time."

Analysing health-related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

John Murray – 1898-1975 – long time Professor at Princeton, then Westminster, with notables such as Machen and VanTil, following on the heels of A.A. and Charles Hodge and B.B. Warfield. BTT describes him as ‘a careful scholar, an eloquent lecturer, a moving preacher, and the author of many outstanding articles and books. Murray’s driving passions were to declare Christ’s Word, advance His cause, and bless His people.’ **Description**

Students investigate ways to access community resources to seek help about health, safety and wellbeing. They then determine criteria for the credibility of a website and evaluate a range of websites and apps.

Learning focus

Students apply health literacy skills to assess the credibility and reliability of a range of health-related websites.

Key understandings

- Health literacy is having the knowledge to find, understand and use information about our own health

~~Analysing health related websites and apps~~

~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

~~and health care, from sources such as websites and apps, to make healthier and safer decisions.~~

- ~~• There is a range of criteria that can be used to assess the credibility and reliability of a health-related website.~~

~~Materials~~

- ~~• A ball of wool or string~~
- ~~• Computer/tablet with internet access [per pair of students]~~
- ~~• Student Activity Sheet: *Internet information* [one per student]~~
- ~~• Student Activity Sheet: *How reliable is that website?* [one per student]~~

~~Before you get started~~

- ~~• Students will be searching the internet for websites and apps in this learning activity. If available, refer to your school's internet usage policy for safe practices when conducting website searches.~~

Analysing health related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

- Teachers should know and understand the protective interrupting technique and what, why, when and how it is needed and used before facilitating this activity.

Learning activities

Whole Class

1. Discuss safety issues students might encounter in their daily life (e.g. road safety, safety around medications, navigating relationships). Whiteboard responses.

2. Ask:—

- How do you KNOW if you're safe or unsafe?
- What feelings and emotions do you experience in a safe and in an unsafe situation?
- How would you deal with being in an unsafe, threatening or uncomfortable situation?
- Where might you go to access community resources if you did not feel safe or wanted to stay safe in this situation? (use the situations

Analysing health related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

on the whiteboard that the students have provided above)

- *What could you do to make sure you understand the information that you might get from these community resources? (e.g. prepare and ask questions; bring an adult relative to the appointment; ask for things to be explained in another way; ask for an interpreter)*

3. Explain that it is important to have the knowledge to be able to find, understand and use information about your health and health care so that you can make healthy decisions. This knowledge is called health literacy. Stress that part of health literacy is being able to decide whether information that you find on the internet is trustworthy and believable.

4. To demonstrate the complexity of finding credible and reliable information, have students gather around your computer and give one student a ball of wool or string and ask them to hold the end. Explain that you are a 12-year-old female student and you are worried because you haven't started your period yet. All your

Analysing health related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

friends have and you want to find out if you are normal by using the internet.

- Type in “*When is it normal to start your period?*” into a search engine and then click on a range of reliable (e.g. government sites) and not so reliable (e.g. YouTube) sites. Each time you click on a site or a link, have the student holding the ball of wool hold onto their end or piece of wool close to the ball and then pass the ball to another student. A cobweb effect should result to demonstrate that searching for appropriate information is complicated.

5. In pairs, have students guess a definition for the terms ‘credible’ and ‘reliable’ and then compare their definitions with a dictionary definition.

- Have students work in pairs or small groups to think about what makes a website credible and reliable and list these as a checklist. Consider:
 - *Who wrote the information or created the website?*

~~Analysing health related websites and apps~~

~~Year 6 Learning Activity~~

- ~~• The date on the website (if applicable)~~
- ~~• Could they find other sources (sites) that had the same information?~~
- ~~• Did the site provide links to other sites, or give sources for its information?~~
- ~~• Ask:~~
 - ~~• When searching a site, what indicates that it's an ad?~~
 - ~~• Why do you get particular ads when you are searching?~~
 - ~~• How do you decide which web page to use? Is it the top one?~~
 - ~~• What do you know about the address?~~

~~6. Explain to students that there are a number of terms and words that can assist them to locate, select, navigate and evaluate appropriate websites and online content.~~

Analysing health-related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

- Provide each student with a copy of the Student Activity Sheet: *Internet information* that lists a number of commonly used terms and pieces of information that can be found on websites. Read through each of them with the students.
- Have students compare this information with the checklists they developed.

Independent or Small Group

1. Give each student a copy of the Student Activity Sheet: *How reliable is that website?*. Explain that they are going to be using the internet to find some information to help their 12-year-old friend who has told them that he/she is feeling sad and depressed. In groups of five, students use the activity sheet to evaluate which website and app from the list below would be the most reliable and useful for their friend:

Reliable websites:

Kids Helpline www.kidshelpline.com.au

Headspace www.eheadspace.org.au

Analysing health related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

Youth Beyond Blue www.youthbeyondblue.com

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Not so reliable websites:

Kids health www.kidshealth.org

Wikihow wikihow.com/Deal-with-Teenage-Depression

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Free reliable apps (downloadable through iTunes or Google Play):

Smiling mind www.smilingmind.com.au

ReachOut WorryTime www.reachout.com/reachout-worrytime-app

ReachOut Breathe www.reachout.com/reachout-breathe-app

Note: Other relationship/sexual health issues could be used as a trigger for this activity. The teacher would need to preview a range of 'child appropriate' reliable and not so reliable sources prior to the lesson.

Analysing health related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

2. Hear feedback from each group on their chosen website and ask that students justify their answers.

Ask:

- For the particular issue you had to deal with, was the web/an app the best place to find help?
- Is the site/app you decided to suggest to your friend as useful as talking to a parent, teacher, doctor or health worker?
- When is the web/an app appropriate/inappropriate?

Reflection

1. Students use the Kids Helpline website to find a topic of interest to them (from the homepage, click on the 'Kids' link then scroll down to the 'Helpful info for you!' section).
2. Students describe how they might use this information to:
 - make better decisions about their health

Analysing health related websites and apps

Year 6 Learning Activity

- advise a friend about an issue that might be bothering them.

Related assets (links to sections within GDHR site)

Teaching Note

Protective interrupting

Teaching resources

Internet information

How reliable is that website

Date printed

25 September 2026